57

As every president since World War II has learned, no region of the world presents America with more difficult, more frustrating, or more convoluted problems than the Middle East. It's a region where hate has roots reaching back to the dawn of history. It's a place where the senseless spilling of blood in the name of religious faith has gone on since biblical times, and where modern events are forever being shaped by momentous events of the past, from the Exodus to the Holocaust.

I never had any illusions that it would be easy, but when I came to the White House in 1981 I hoped to build on the peace process in the Middle East that had been started by Jimmy Carter at Camp David, where Egypt and Israel signed a treaty ending their thirty-year state of war. Although we had moments of progress, and at times we managed to bottle up at least temporarily the savagery that forever lies beneath the sands of the Middle East, the region was still an adders' nest of problems when I moved out of the White House eight years later. And along the way it had been the source of some of my administration's most difficult moments.

There are two intertwined conflicts in this cauldron of hate and strife—one over territory, the other over religion. Each has roots centuries old.

At one level, there is the dispute between Arab and Jew over the land called Palestine. More than three thousand years ago, at the time of Abraham and Moses, a great Hebrew civilization blossomed in this corner of the ancient Fertile Crescent and flourished until the Jews were overrun